

THE MOVE

Could you [specific action] within [scope / time / effort] by [when]? If not, [release or smaller alternative]. -> Could you review just the final paragraph by noon? No full edit needed. -> Could you reply with a yes or no by tomorrow? No explanatio...

START HERE

Ask for one specific action, add one honest boundary, and leave an honest no-or-adjust route.

SAY THIS

Quick asks	"One small ask: can you reply yes or no by tomorrow?"
Workplace & review	"Could you review just the final paragraph by noon? No full edit needed."
Delegation & owners...	"Could you update the numbers on slides four to six? I will handle wording and design."
Relationship & home	"Could you help with just the dishes tonight? I am not asking you to handle the whole kitchen."
Power-sensitive & hi...	"This may well be a no. Could you consider one small part — reviewing the timeline only?"
Release & exit lines	"A quick no is completely fine."

AVOID

- The situation is urgent and a tidy boundary would hide the real seriousness
- The request affects safety, consent, medical or legal decisions, or employment rights
- The actual ask is large and should be discussed openly rather than shrunk

REMEMBER

Make the cost visible before you ask for the yes.